military coup. Embroiled in wars with most of Burma's ethnic communities (and facing a serious challenge from the Burmese Communist Party), the military came to distrust the population of the country and looked for a unifying ideology. Initially this was the idea of a uniquely 'Burmese Road to Socialism',[61] and this was allied to a sense that Buddhism could also form a unifying role.

Politically, the generals maintained the veneer of a civilian government. Thus, after 1974 they ruled through the Burmese Socialist Programme Party.[62] Equally, the military contained multiple factions and this led to various attempted coups and changes in leadership. Ne Win finally fell in 1988 after pro-democracy demonstrations had shaken the regime. For the 1990 elections the military formed the National Unity Party, which performed disastrously.[63] When it was forced to reinstate some degree of democracy after 2008, it was clear it had learnt some lessons from this episode. Its new political vehicle was the USDP, and this time it took out an insurance policy against setbacks in the democratic process: 25 per cent of the seats in the new parliament were reserved for the USDP and these were allocated to serving officers.

The fundamental problem is that the military still controls Myanmar[64] and do not have the slightest intention of withdrawing from politics. It needs to retain political power to protect its substantial economic interests, and, importantly, its belief that only it can represent the nation is at the core of its approach.[65] This is not to say it is a unitary body: there are clear and ongoing indications of factional disputes,[66] in part about how to interact with the NLD, and also about the relative importance of international links.

However, rigging the electoral system (25 per cent of seats are still guaranteed for the military's political party) is not the only insurance policy it took out. There is growing evidence that the MaBaTha Buddhist extremist organisation was set up by the military as an alternative power base.[67] To understand why it may have done this, it is useful first to survey the rest of the current political scene.

The 'national' political parties

Currently there are two notionally multi-ethnic, multi-confessional parties: the military-created USDP and the opposition NLD. The latter emerged